Group 4 — Our Own Strait of Hormuz: the ultranationalist case

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Our position: Small countries that control a chokepoint are not small. Panama has a canal. Egypt has Suez. Iran has Hormuz, and in 2026 it proved that whoever holds the strait sets the terms for everyone else. Canada is sitting on the only northern route between the Atlantic and the Pacific and is apologizing for owning it. Declare the Passage closed to anyone without a Canadian permit, charge for transit, escort every ship, and make Washington, Beijing and Moscow ask us nicely.

Briefing

The legal foundation already exists. Canada's official position is that the waters of the Arctic archipelago are *internal waters*, the same status as a lake, meaning foreign ships need permission to enter. The United States and, generally, the European Union say the Passage is an *international strait* open to transit without asking (Inland Ocean guide). Even a commentator sympathetic to the American view admits that if Canada's claim were accepted, Canada could legally bar Russian or Chinese naval vessels outright (GeoGarage, Sept. 2026). This group's argument is that a claim nobody enforces is a claim nobody respects, and the way to settle it is to act like an owner.

The 2026 model is Iran. After the Iran war, Tehran created a "Persian Gulf Strait Authority" in May 2026 to collect tolls from ships using the Strait of Hormuz; paying guaranteed safe passage, and the United States threatened sanctions on any shipper who paid (Wikipedia, PGSA; Maritime Executive). This group does not admire Iran. It notes that a mid-sized power with a chokepoint forced the entire global economy to deal with it.

The geography is favourable. Grays Bay sits near the midpoint of the roughly 6,000 km route from Nome, Alaska, to Nuuk, Greenland (North of 60, Jan. 2026). A Canadian deepwater port and naval station there would sit astride every transit. Dutch shipper Royal Wagenborg reports the Passage cuts about 3,750 nautical miles and two weeks off a Panama routing between Asia and the east coast (USNI Proceedings, Sept. 2025). As the Arctic warms at four times the global rate, India and Japan are already planning their own 2027 Arctic voyages (Berkeley Political Review, Oct. 14, 2026).

And the threat is not hypothetical. The Trump administration's National Security Strategy named the Northwest Passage a "key strategic location," and analysts warn the most tempting move for Washington would be to sail a US Navy or Coast Guard vessel through without asking, a so-called freedom-of-navigation operation (Policy Magazine, Feb. 2026). If Greenland's new US defence deal gives Washington a foothold to the east and Alaska to the west, the Passage is surrounded (High North News, June 2026). To this group, the answer to encirclement is not negotiation. It is a toll booth with a frigate behind it.

> "The Americans respect exactly one thing: a fact on the ground. Put a Canadian escort on every hull in that Passage and the lawyers in Washington will suddenly discover the merits of our position." — *Gord Lavallee, True North First Movement* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.